Vladimir Ilyich Lenin (1870–1924): Lenin was born near the Middle Volga. In 1887 his eldest brother was hanged for taking part in an attempt on the Tsar's life. Influenced by the ideas of Karl Marx, Lenin believed that the way for freedom was through mass action. He spent his time taking classes for study groups of factory workers in St Petersburg on Marxism. Arrested in 1895 he was kept in Siberia. After his release in 1900, he moved from one boarding house to another in the big cities of Europe. In 1903 a congress of forty-three delegates of the Social Democratic Party, the chief party of the left, moved to London. Here the congress split on the issue of organisation and strategy. Lenin gained the support of a small majority (*bolshinstvo*), known as Bolsheviks, which became the Bolshevik Party. His opponents, in a minority (*menshinstvo*), were called Mensheviks.



Lenin

scientists and writers suffered imprisonment and exile for expressing opinions. The Tsars were universally hated and everyone looked forward to their downfall.

Conditions of Peasantry

Russia was basically a peasant society. Nearly one-half of the population were serfs tied to the land. Russian peasants were forced to labour on their lords' lands for a few days every week without any payment, and were not allowed to marry without the consent of the lords. Serfs were punished severely even for minor faults.During the reign of Nicholas I, there were more than five hundred serf riots in various parts of Russia, but they were all crushed ruthlessly. Alexander II issued an edict of emancipation in 1861 and freed the serfs. But they were not provided with land to eke out their livelihood. So the peasants became the combustible material for the revolution.

Industrial backwardness and abominable living condition of working class

Russia began to industrialise late. Russia lagged behind all great European powers. Russian workers laboured under oppressive conditions. Trade unions and strikes were completely banned. The Russian working class was looking for an opportunity to protest.

Role of Nihilists

The young, radical and non-gentry intellectuals who waged a merciless war against the Russian state were called Nihilists by their enemies. The first unsuccessful attempt on the life of Tsar Alexander II and innumerable trials that followed dubbing the suspected intellectuals as nihilists and sending them, both men and women, to Siberia did not stop their revolutionary activities in Russia. Revolutionary forces swelled, as many minority groups such as the Jews and Poles joined them.

Nihilism represented a revolt against the established social order. It rejected all authority exercised by the state, by the church and by the family. It based its belief on nothing but scientific truth.

Marxism and Its Influence

Marx and Engels held the firm view that the existence of the *bourgeoisie* was as necessary a condition for the Socialist revolution as the proletariat. They never envisaged the possibility of a successful Socialist revolution in backward Russia. However, Marxist ideas, apart from other radical ideas such as anarchism and various forms of socialism, gained ground in a situation were living conditions were oppressive. But Marxist groups were in the lead, and in Lenin they found a charismatic leader with great organisational skills.

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